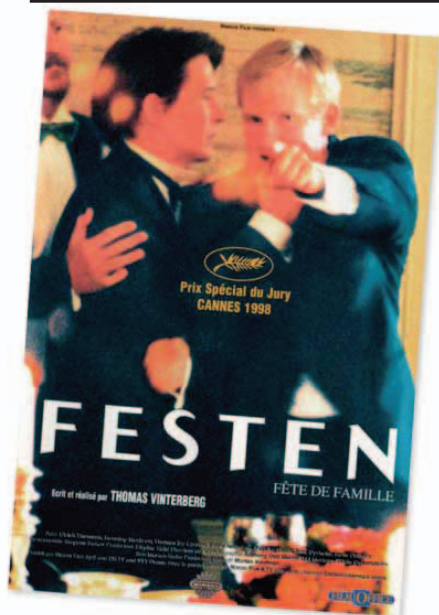


What else to watch: *The 400 Blows* (1959, pp.150–55) ■ *À bout de souffle* (1960, pp.166–67) ■ *Breaking the Waves* (1996, p.341) ■ *The Idiots* (1998) ■ *Julien Donkey-Boy* (1999) ■ *The King is Alive* (2000) ■ *Dear Wendy* (2004) ■ *The Hunt* (2012)



politeness. Traditional speeches are often a contrived conversation that is used to mask an agenda or keep the peace—it lends itself to dishonesty. In *Festen*, however, it is where characters are at their most honest. Once they have tapped a wine glass with a fork, they bare their souls.

In his first speech, Christian (Ulrich Thomsen), the eldest son of the patriarch Helge (Henning Moritzen), accuses his father of committing a terrible crime against his children years earlier, one that ultimately led to his twin sister's death. In this moment, Christian is fearless, yet a few moments later his father speaks to him privately and the mask returns—Christian apologizes and recants. The party, and the speeches, continue. For a

After making a terrible and very public accusation against his father, Christian (Ulrich Tomsen, center) is forcibly ejected from the patriarch's birthday party by his younger brother Michael (Thomas Bo Larsen, left).

In removing artifice, *Festen* was a self-consciously “little” movie, in the tradition of the French New Wave. It cost just over \$1 million to make.

family whose private conversations have been full of lies for so long, it makes sense that the structural artifice of the speech becomes the place to find honesty.

Anarchy and order

The Dogme 95 principle was a much-needed stripping back of frippery in the guise of punish prank, ridding cinema of overly familiar trappings in order to get right to the soul of the piece.

Festen was one of the first movies to use digital cameras, and this gives it the feel of an uncompromising family video, putting the viewer in the center of the emotional firestorm. In doing so, it makes the audience forget that it is watching a “movie.” There are no musical cues to tell viewers when to be upset, no empowering scenes of revenge. The movie presents the disintegration of a family with a minimum of directorial comment, leaving the audience free to decide what to feel, when to be horrified or amazed. By affording the viewer such trust, *Festen* leaves an affecting emotional mark. ■

“Don’t diss my family, get it?”

Michael / Festen

